PROPOSAL FOR HOSPITAL PARTNERSHIP AND PILOT EVALUATION

SUBMITTED BY	Unmute
PROGRAMME	Unmute Healthcare Communication Initiative
PROPOSED PARTNERS	Hospitals and Healthcare Institutions
PURPOSE	Institutional Collaboration, Product Evaluation, and Potential Pilot Partnership

1 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Unmute is an AI-powered communication technology initiative focused on reducing communication barriers between Deaf individuals and hearing people.

Our initial product focuses on healthcare, where communication barriers between Deaf patients and healthcare professionals can make routine interactions difficult, time-consuming, and stressful.

Deaf patients may struggle to communicate symptoms, describe discomfort, understand medical instructions, or respond to questions during consultations. Healthcare professionals may also lack the sign-language skills or immediate access to qualified interpreters needed to facilitate these interactions.

Unmute is developing a technology-assisted communication platform designed to support two-way communication between Deaf patients and hearing healthcare professionals through sign-language recognition and speech-to-sign technology.

We are seeking partnerships with healthcare institutions to validate the problem, evaluate the proposed solution, gather clinical feedback, and establish a pathway towards controlled pilot deployments.

We invite interested hospitals to express their interest through a Letter of Intent (LOI), indicating their willingness to explore collaboration with Unmute.

2 THE PROBLEM

Communication accessibility remains a significant challenge for Deaf patients accessing healthcare services.

During routine hospital interactions, communication may depend on:

- Written notes or text messages.
- Lip-reading, which may not always be reliable.
- Gestures and improvised communication.
- Relatives or accompanying persons acting as informal interpreters.
- The availability of professional sign-language interpreters.

These alternatives may introduce delays, misunderstandings, privacy concerns, and additional pressure on both patients and healthcare professionals.

The challenge is not simply the absence of communication. It is the difficulty of achieving clear, timely, and independent communication during healthcare interactions.

3 OUR PROPOSED SOLUTION

Unmute is developing an AI-assisted healthcare communication platform designed to facilitate communication between Deaf patients and hearing healthcare professionals.

The initial MVP will focus on American Sign Language (ASL), with a controlled set of healthcare-related expressions.

The intended capabilities include:

A. HEALTHCARE PROFESSIONAL TO DEAF PATIENT

- Spoken English input through a device microphone.
- Conversion of speech into text.
- Mapping of supported English expressions to corresponding ASL representations.
- Display of the corresponding sign-language video or avatar.

B. DEAF PATIENT TO HEALTHCARE PROFESSIONAL

- Camera-based capture of supported signing.
- Recognition of supported sign-language expressions.
- Conversion of recognised expressions into English text.
- Optional text-to-speech output.

C. COMMUNICATION SUPPORT

- Repetition and clarification options.
- Manual phrase selection where automatic recognition is unavailable.
- Clear indication when an expression is unsupported or cannot be confidently recognised.

The initial product will be limited to supported expressions and will be evaluated with Deaf users and healthcare professionals before any broader deployment.

Unmute is intended to support routine communication. It is not being presented as a replacement for qualified interpreters during emergencies, informed consent, complex clinical discussions, or other high-stakes interactions.

4 OBJECTIVES OF THE PROPOSED PARTNERSHIP

We seek to collaborate with healthcare institutions to:

1. Validate the communication challenges experienced by Deaf patients and healthcare professionals.
2. Obtain feedback from relevant clinical personnel on the proposed solution.
3. Evaluate the usability and practical relevance of the Unmute MVP.
4. Identify suitable routine healthcare interactions for initial testing.
5. Understand institutional requirements for accessibility technology adoption.
6. Establish a pathway towards a controlled pilot programme.
7. Explore the potential for continued institutional adoption following successful evaluation.

5 PROPOSED AREAS OF COLLABORATION

We invite interested hospitals to consider the following forms of participation.

A. INSTITUTIONAL INTEREST AND ENGAGEMENT

- Nominate a representative to serve as the hospital's point of contact.
- Participate in discussions about the communication challenges experienced by Deaf patients.
- Provide feedback on the proposed product and its relevance to the hospital's operations.

B. CLINICAL AND USER FEEDBACK

- Identify relevant doctors, nurses, or healthcare professionals who can review the proposed workflows.
- Provide feedback on the healthcare phrases and interactions prioritised for the MVP.
- Where appropriate, support supervised usability testing with consenting participants.

C. MVP EVALUATION

Subject to product readiness and institutional approval, the hospital may participate in a controlled evaluation of the Unmute MVP.

This may involve:

- Demonstrations to relevant healthcare personnel.
- Testing selected routine communication scenarios.
- Feedback on usability, accuracy, response time, and practical limitations.
- Documentation of issues and recommendations for improvement.

D. POTENTIAL PILOT PARTNERSHIP

Following a successful initial evaluation, both parties may explore a more structured pilot programme.

The scope, duration, participating department, number of users, evaluation criteria, and operational arrangements would be agreed upon separately.

6 WHAT WE ARE REQUESTING FROM PARTICIPATING HOSPITALS

At this stage, we are not requesting a financial commitment or an immediate purchase.

We are seeking an initial expression of institutional interest through a non-binding Letter of Intent.

The proposed LOI would indicate the hospital's willingness to:

- Explore a potential partnership with Unmute.
- Participate in discussions and product demonstrations.
- Nominate an appropriate institutional contact.
- Consider providing clinical and operational feedback.
- Explore participation in a controlled MVP evaluation, subject to approval and product readiness.
- Discuss the possibility of a future pilot if the evaluation is satisfactory.

Any actual testing involving patients, clinical workflows, or personal information would require appropriate institutional authorisation, consent, privacy safeguards, and clinical oversight.

An LOI would not constitute a commitment to purchase, deploy, or recommend the product.

7 RESPONSIBILITIES OF UNMUTE

Unmute intends to:

- Develop and maintain the MVP.
- Provide product demonstrations and relevant documentation.
- Clearly communicate supported capabilities and known limitations.
- Coordinate product testing and collect appropriate feedback.
- Address identified technical issues within the agreed scope.
- Protect information collected during any approved evaluation.
- Provide an evaluation summary where agreed.

- Work with the hospital to define suitable next steps.

8 EXPECTED OUTCOMES

The proposed collaboration is expected to help:

- Improve understanding of communication barriers affecting Deaf patients.
- Identify practical use cases for assistive communication technology.
- Evaluate the relevance and usability of Unmute in healthcare settings.
- Generate feedback to guide product development.
- Establish institutional relationships for potential future pilot programmes.
- Contribute to more accessible healthcare communication.

9 PROPOSED NEXT STEPS

We propose the following engagement process:

1. ASLIN facilitates an introduction between Unmute and interested healthcare institutions.
2. Interested hospitals review this proposal and the accompanying LOI.
3. The hospital indicates its interest through an authorised representative.
4. Unmute schedules an introductory meeting and product demonstration.
5. Both parties discuss the appropriate evaluation scope and institutional requirements.
6. If mutually agreed, a pilot evaluation plan is developed.

10 CONCLUSION

Accessible communication is an important part of equitable healthcare delivery.

Unmute believes technology can help reduce some of the barriers Deaf patients encounter when communicating with healthcare professionals. However, building a useful solution requires collaboration with the institutions and people who experience these challenges directly.

We welcome the opportunity to work with healthcare institutions to evaluate this approach, improve the product through practical feedback, and explore a sustainable model for accessible healthcare communication.

CONTACT DETAILS

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